WEST BENGAL

BIRBHUM BOWS TO THE BAHUBALI

By Romita Datta

In Bengal, even Robin Hood figures can come draped in a halo of grey. Whether the stories surrounding him be fact or legend, one man who exemplifies this is Anubrata Mondal. Of all the Trinamool Congress strongmen who rule their fiefdoms with an iron grip, Mondal is perhaps the most formidable. The party's Birbhum district chief, he leapfrogged from those boondocks to hit the mainstream news circuit when his name was whispered in connection with the revenge killings on March 21 at Bagtui village, where nine people were charred alive. Birbhum, upwards of 150 km north from Kolkata and home to Tagore's Santiniketan, is mired in a petty gridlock of organised crime. And he comes with the reputation of being the master of ceremonies. Locals say "even a fly cannot enter Birbhum without Anubrata's knowledge". How, then, his opponets ask, could an incident such as Bagtui come to pass unbidden—even if he has claimed ignorance?

But that's speculation, and that isn't why the CBI is after Anubrata. If he has confined himself to a VVIP cabin of the state's premier government hospital, SSKM in Calcutta, it's because of repeated summons in a multi-crore cattle smuggling case. He has given the slip to the agency five times by now. With the Calcutta High Court refusing to grant him relief in the case, his time may be running out. The CBI is keeping an eagle eye on his well-being, even as his followers perform a *yajna* back home.

Anubrata has had some good practice dodging the central sleuths of late—in January, he cited 'medical' reasons for playing AWOL in the probe into the alleged murder of Gourab Sarkar, a BJP supporter from Illambazar. And in February, the wily satrap sought, and was granted, immunity from arrest by the HC when the CBI wanted to question him in its probe into post-poll violence in Bengal. Bagtui went up in flames after that, as if controversy has made a habit of shadowing the man. As the rich array of cases in which he's being tailed will tell you, the CBI, too, has a kind of single-minded focus in its manhunt. The opposition BJP, which has long accused him of inspiring various acts of violence and has often been at the receiving end of his abrasive barbs, would surely rejoice at the sight of his scalp. Kunal Ghosh, official Trinamool spokesperson, says as much: "The BJP cannot get even with him politically, so they are using the agency to harass him. Why is all this talk of extortion and smuggling surfacing? Because the CBI wants it to."

ANUBRATA MONDAL IS SAID TO BE THE NODAL POINT FOR THE RS 200 CRORE 'COLLECTIONS' FROM BIRBHUM

But the 62-year-old lends himself to a touch of outlaw mystique, even if he's squarely within the system. The backstory is typical of the muscle and patronage networks that ruled Bengal during the Jyoti Basu era. Anubrata's talents were apparent early on: studies till Class IV, the image of a bully in childhood, and the usual gradation of attempted careers—grocery, supplying coal, land deals—before politics. In a Birbhum then considered a CPI(M) bastion, Congress leader Sushovan Banerjee roped in the young man they called 'Keshto'. But his real break came when Mamata Banerjee formed the TMC in 1998; the killing of 11 pro-party labourers in Suchpur, Birbhum, in 2000 being a turning point. Determined to get justice for the victims, he collected money

ARRAIGNING ANUBRATA MONDAL

- The CBI wants to quiz him in the multi-crore cattle smuggling case. Anubrata's name came up when the alleged kingpin, Enamul Haque, was interrogated
- He has been asked to depose in the alleged murder of a person at Illambazar in May 2021
- He was one of the 41 accused in the alleged murder of Sagar Ghosh, an independent who won a panchayat seat in Parui, Birbhum, in 2013. He was given a clean chit in 2014
- Whispered links to the Bagtui killings of March 21

